

The Honest One-to-One

A one-to-one usually gets you a status update. Here is how to run it so the thing they actually need to say comes up, and the worksheet to do it yourself this week.

For **Managers**

Format **One-to-one, in-person or remote**

Time **25–30 min**

Difficulty **2 of 3**

This worksheet runs solo. No facilitator, no prep beyond reading it once before your next one-to-one.

Why This Works

A status update is the safest thing a person can hand you. It carries no risk. It reports what a task is doing rather than what the person is doing, and the brain reaches for it by default. When someone is unsure how a piece of candour will land, the threat-detection system treats honesty as exposure. Cortisol rises, attention narrows, and they give you the version of events that cannot be used against them later. “Fine, busy, on track” is not laziness. It is self-protection running on autopilot.

The brain answers the question it is actually asked. “How’s it going?” is a doorway into nothing, so it gets a reflexive “good.” A specific, recent, concrete question gives the brain something it can retrieve, and the answer that comes back has detail in it. Detail is where the truth lives.

There is a second mechanism worth knowing about. When a person puts a feeling into words, activity in the amygdala drops and the prefrontal cortex comes back online. Researchers call it affect labelling. The practical consequence is that your job in a one-to-one is not to solve whatever they raise. It is to make it safe enough that they name the thing out loud, because the naming itself settles them enough to think clearly. Managers who jump to fixing skip the step that does the work.

Trust is what makes any of this possible, and trust is not built inside the meeting. It is built between meetings, in whether you did what you said you would. Oxytocin, the chemistry of reliable connection, accrues through follow-through and undivided attention over time. One good conversation does not earn you the hard truth. A run of conversations where the truth was safe and then acted on does.

IF THEY ASK WHY THE ONE-TO-ONE IS CHANGING

“I realised I’ve been using this time to get a status update I can already get from the board. That’s a waste of your half hour. I want to change what we do with it, so it’s actually useful to you.”

Before You Begin

This worksheet has one prerequisite, and it sits with you rather than them. The questions below only work if the person already has evidence that telling you the truth is safe. Without that evidence, the same questions read as an interrogation.

MANAGER HONESTY CHECK

Do not run this as a truth-surfacing meeting if any of these are true right now:

- The last time someone told you something hard, it cost them something. They remember, even if

you have forgotten.

- You only book a one-to-one when there is a problem, so the meeting itself reads as a threat signal before anyone speaks.
- You will hear the truth and then take the problem off them, which teaches them that honesty means losing control of their own work.
- You intend to ask for candour and then glance at your phone.

If one of these is true, the fix comes before the questions. Run a couple of low-stakes one-to-ones where nothing is wrong, listen, and follow through on one small thing. Earn the evidence first.

The One-to-One

Twenty-five to thirty minutes. The timings are a guide, not a script to race through. If a phase opens something real, stay in it and let the later phases shrink.

Phase 0: Set the frame *(one time only, 2 minutes)*

You do this once, at the first meeting, and never again. It tells the brain what kind of room this is.

WHAT TO SAY

"This is your meeting, not my status check. I get status from the board. This time is for the things the board doesn't show me. You bring what's worth talking about. If you've got nothing, we use it to talk about where you're heading. I'll protect the slot. I'll only move it if something's on fire, and I'll rebook it the same week."

Phase 1: Open away from the status trap *(3 minutes)*

Do not open with "what are you working on" or "where are we with X." That opens the status door and the rest of the meeting walks through it. Open with something that signals the meeting is about them.

WHAT TO SAY (PICK ONE)

"What's been on your mind this week that we haven't talked about?"

"On a normal day this week, what took more out of you than it should have?"

"What went better than you expected, and what went worse?"

The paired version matters. Asking only for the problem can feel like an audit. Pairing a good thing with a hard thing gives them a safe way in and a true one.

Phase 2: Get the real answer *(12 minutes)*

This is the core of the meeting. There are three moves and they run in order.

Ask specific and recent. Trade the vague question for the concrete one. Not "how's the project," but "what's the part of the project you'd quietly redo if you had the time." The Question Bank below is built for this.

Hold the silence. After you ask, stop talking. The first answer is the rehearsed one. The real one arrives after a pause that most managers cannot bear and so fill in for them. Count to five before you speak.

WHAT NOT TO SAY (THE SILENCE-FILLERS THAT HAND THEM THE EXIT)

"No worries if not."

"It's probably nothing."

"I'm sure it's fine."

Label what you hear, before you fix it. Reflect the thing under the thing, then stop again so they can correct you.

WHAT TO SAY

"It sounds like the part that's actually wearing on you is the handovers, not the workload itself. Have I got that right?"

"So if I'm hearing it correctly, the issue isn't the deadline, it's that nobody told you it moved."

Phase 3: The question most managers skip (5 minutes)

The direct one. Ask it plainly, once there is some trust in the bank, and not every single week. It is the cheap, early version of a conversation you otherwise have far too late.

WHAT TO SAY (PICK ONE)

"Are you still glad you came to work here? Be straight with me, I can take it."

"If you were going to leave, what would the reason be? I'd rather hear it now as a hypothetical than later as a resignation."

"What's the one thing about this job that, if it never changes, will eventually make you look elsewhere?"

If the answer has heat in it, that is signal, not noise. Treat a real answer here as the earliest warning you will get.

Phase 4: Close with your commitments (3 minutes)

End by naming what you will do, by when, in their words. This is where trust compounds or leaks. Do not over-promise. One concrete commitment that you keep is worth more than five that you mean at the time.

WHAT TO SAY

"Here's what I heard, and here's the one thing I'm going to do about it by Thursday. If it doesn't happen, call it out at our next one."

Write it down where they can see you writing it. The act of writing is itself a signal that what they said registered.

The Question Bank

Swap the status-trap question for one of these, matched to what you are trying to surface. Use one or two per meeting, not a list. The point is a real answer, not coverage.

Workload and capacity (what is actually heavy)

- What did you spend time on this week that you don't think was worth it?
- If you could hand one task to someone else tomorrow, what would it be and why that one?
- When did you last feel genuinely behind, and what caused it?

Growth and boredom (the quiet disengagement)

- What part of your job has stopped teaching you anything?
- If nothing changed about your role for the next year, how would you feel about that?
- What would you want to be doing here that you're not doing now?

Belonging and the team (who they lean on, who they avoid)

- Who on the team do you go to when you're stuck, and is that working?
- Is there anyone here you find it hard to work with right now?
- When something goes wrong, do you feel like you can say so early, or do you sit on it?

You, the manager (the bravest one to ask)

- What's something I do that makes your job harder?
- When have I been least useful to you lately?
- What do you wish I'd ask you about that I never do?

The unsaid (catch-alls that open doors)

- What's the thing you almost mentioned today and decided not to?
- If you ran this team, what's the first thing you'd change?
- What am I missing?

RETIRE THESE. THEY PRODUCE THE STATUS UPDATE, NOT THE TRUTH

"How's everything going?" · "All good?" · "Anything for me?" · "Any blockers?"

Each one is answerable in a single safe word, which is exactly why people use them to close the door.

Facilitation Notes

When they say "everything's fine." Do not accept it and move on. Follow it with a question that gives fine somewhere to go: "Good. Tell me the thing that's only a small annoyance now but would be a real problem in three months." Or remove the cost of answering: "What would your honest answer be if I promised not to act on it today?"

When the silence gets uncomfortable. That discomfort is the work happening. Do not rescue it. The person is deciding whether to give you the rehearsed answer or the real one, and if you speak, you decide it for them. Sit in it longer than feels natural.

When they tell you something hard. Your first instinct will be to explain why it is actually fine, or to fix it on the spot. Both punish the disclosure. Instead, label it and thank them: “Thank you for telling me that, it took something to say.” Then ask one question that goes deeper before you go anywhere near a solution.

When the hard thing is you. This is the highest-trust outcome a one-to-one can produce, and it is the easiest to destroy by accident. Do not defend yourself in the room. “I’m glad you told me. Give me the specific moment, so I can see what you saw.” Take it away, sit with it, and come back to it next time. Defending it once teaches them never to raise it again.

When they bring nothing, week after week. Read it as data about the meeting, not about the person. Either the trust is not there yet, or the meeting still reads as a threat. Do not interrogate your way out of it. Go back to listening and visible follow-through on small things until the room feels safe enough to use.

Signs This Is Working

You will not get a dramatic confession in week one. The change shows up as a pattern over a few weeks.

- Problems reach you earlier and smaller, before they have grown into something that needs its own meeting.
- They start bringing the agenda instead of waiting to be asked.
- The meeting occasionally runs over, because there is real material in it rather than a recital.
- You hear the hard thing without having to dig for it.
- You stop being surprised by resignations.

Remote / Hybrid Adaptation

Camera on for both of you, and nothing else open on your screen. People can tell when you are reading something, and a divided screen reads as “this is not important,” which closes them down faster than any wrong question.

Silence is harder to hold on video, so name it rather than filling it: “I’m going to give you a second to think, the pause is fine.” Naming the pause keeps it from feeling like a frozen call.

Offer an async lane for the people who think in writing. A two-line note before the call on what is worth their half hour lowers the threat for anyone who freezes when put on the spot live.

Protect the slot harder than you would in person. A cancelled remote one-to-one is the easiest trust to lose and the hardest to notice you have lost.

Cross-Pillar Connections

- **Run V1 (Vulnerability Circle) first** if disclosure is low across the whole team, not just one person. One-to-ones surface individual truth; V1 builds the group trust that makes candour normal.
- **Pairs with the feedback worksheets (Communication).** The labelling move in Phase 2 is the same muscle as receiving feedback without defending, which is the work in those sheets.

- **Feeds the Reflection pillar.** The direct question in Phase 3 is the live, spoken version of the written reflection prompts.
- **Connects to the 42-Day resignation work.** Phase 3 is the early and cheap version of the conversation that, left to the signals alone, you tend to have two weeks after it would have mattered.